interest and the welfare of street dogs at large," says Abodh Aras, CEO, The Welfare of Stray Dogs, Mumbai.

Those who are fighting against feeding strays say that there should be someone to take responsibility for the dogs should they attack another person or pet dog. "I am an animal lover myself," says 35-year-old Sonali Batra, a homemaker from Pune. "But I don't feed dogs outside because I cannot take responsibility for them." Most feeders, however, are unwilling to take the responsibility. For example, Vanya Jha, a Bhopal-based lawyer who regularly feeds strays, says, "I would help in treatment if there is a dog bite but not as an obligation, unless the stray has been fully adopted by me, in which case it would not be a stray. In any case, strays are usually fed not by just one person or family, so one person cannot be expected to take up such a responsibility."

Legally, everyone has the right to provide food and care for starving animals. In 2021, the Delhi High Court held that "...animals have a right to live with respect and dignity". The court further declared that "it shall be the duty and responsibility of the RWA (residents' welfare association) or municipal corporation and all government authorities, including enforcement authorities like police, to provide all assistance and ensure that no hindrance is caused to the caregivers or feeders of community animals". The Supreme Court also upheld the judgment in its May 19, 2022, order. In 2014, the apex court had also ruled that any restriction on the feeding of community animals or their removal or any cruelty inflicted on them would be in direct violation of their right to live with dignity. Yet, feeders often find themselves and the dogs they look after at the receiving end of the stick. "I have been abused and yelled at publicly by male members in the society for feeding the dogs. I have been threatened that if the dog harms anyone, they will beat me up. But I stand my ground against such bullies. These are the same people who will berate others for harming the society and then will burst firecrackers and litter the streets with toxic waste that is far more harmful than a dog," says 28-year-old Aditi Chaturvedi, an MBA student in Noida who feeds nine stray dogs outside her PG accommodation.

Those who have been working with stray dogs, such as Kartick Satyanarayan, executive member of Delhi-based NGO Friendicoes, say the solution cannot be found if the responsibility is to be put only on feeders. "If we find ourselves living next to someone we dislike, do we constantly go and harass them till they move away? The answer is to coexist and find ways to do so," he says. The first thing to really consider, Satyanarayan adds, is the fact that India has one of the most successful stray dog control programmes in the world. "Municipalities and NGOs work to sterilise dogs, which has reduced the number on the streets already. These dogs are also vaccinated and by law are returned to the place they were taken from," he says. In Delhi, for example, the municipal corporation has an app where you can request a local dog to be sterilised and even track its surgery and date of release data. Roughly 40,000 dogs are being sterilised annually in south Delhi alone. "The idea is not to kill off the entire feral dog population but



MANDAR DEODHAR

WHAT TO DO IN A STRAY DOG'S TERRITORY

DO NOT THROW THINGS AT DOGS, charge at them or attempt to threaten them with loud sounds and hand gestures. These can startle them, frighten them and make them aggressive. Help young children also understand how to treat and respect stray dogs

DOGS WILL GENERALLY NOT ATTACK UNLESS PROVOKED. If, however, you come across a dog growling, do not run away. Stand your ground, letting the dog know you are not afraid, and slowly continue walking. Ask for help if needed, a dog will usually back away if it sees multiple humans

10%

All-India decline in street dog population, from 2012 to 2019

50%

Drop in street dog population in the past 10 years in Uttar Pradesh, the sharpest fall

36%

Of the world's rabies deaths happen in India

Sources: The State of Pet Homelessness Index data; Lok Sabha figures; WHO